



same building caught fire and soon the whole building, including our offices and R&D labs, was ablaze. I just stood there wondering, what else could go wrong NOW!”

For anyone else, this would have been the end, but for Sanjay, who knew how to find the silver lining behind every cloud, this couldn't be the end. “I'm not saying I didn't feel tired, low, or frustrated. Of course, I did, but I had two things—the support of my family and my team, and a good night's sleep. Every morning, I woke up and reminded myself that for every problem there is a solution,” he shares.

Being a leader, Sanjay never lost hope and helped rebuild the team's confidence. He and his co-founders ensured that no junior employees' salaries were cut, while the senior executives took salary cuts. “The infrastructure could be rebuilt but the team members and their knowledge were priceless, and we did everything we could to keep the team intact. Apart from a six-day delay after the fire, all salaries were



Sanjay Nayak with wife Anju, and sons Shravan and Anmol

issued on time,” he states proudly. “We managed to salvage some equipment from the fire. We also had to fight to get our claims from the insurance company, since there weren't many similar precedents of insurance claims of damaged high-tech equipment,” he adds.

Sanjay took on the role of keeping the team motivated, with his infectious optimism, and eventually overcame the obstacles to grow revenues and profits, and reignited the dream to take the company public. Tejas Networks launched an IPO in 2017, making it the first deep-tech electronics product company in the country to go public. Today Tejas Networks is valued at over ₹200 billion. Its products are deployed in all telecom networks in India, and across more than 75 countries globally.

Despite these wins, Sanjay's desire to make a world-renowned product development company still

felt incomplete. He realised that to make Tejas a global leader, the company needed a bigger balance sheet and a stronger brand to expand its international business. So, when Tata Sons approached Tejas in 2021, to make a strategic investment and take a controlling stake, Sanjay saw the opportunity to fulfil his dream and make Tejas Networks a legacy product development company, with a global footprint. Sanjay and a few senior executives worked with Tata Sons in confidence and pulled off this deal within three weeks of shaking hands.

“I feel happy that I got multiple opportunities to work and develop cutting edge technologies during my career,” he says but cautions against the unexpected challenges. “It's about controlling the controllables. When you do something about your situation, there's a sense of accomplishment. You claim little victories, and those successes give you strength. The next day, you're better off than you were yesterday,” he explains.

After serving as the founding MD and CEO for 23 eventful years, and securing an order book of nearly ₹100 billion, Sanjay felt that it was time to pass the baton to the Tatas, who would ensure the success and growth of the company for several years to come. He had set an example that an Indian electronics product development company from India could take on global behemoths and be well poised for long-term success. The challenge that he had undertaken was now resolved and he decided to step down from

Less known facts about Sanjay Nayak

Favourite Movie: Anand

Favourite Actor: Aamir Khan

Favourite Actress: Madhuri Dixit

Favourite Food: Italian, Thai

Favourite Drink: Fresh-lime soda

Favourite Travel Destination: Italy

Favourite Book: The one I am reading now!

Real Life Role Model/Inspiration: Dr Gururaj Deshpande (Co-founder, Tejas Networks), Late Shiv Shankar Nayak (Father)